

EXT. SPLA BASE - DAY

Chaos. Arab war cries. Horses clomp. Gunfire fills the air, peppers the ground. The injured scream and wail.

A YOUNG BOY in shorts and JELLY SHOES crouches next to a hut. Frozen in fear.

A hand grabs him by the shirt. The boy rises, sprints for his life. But as he does, he loses one shoe. He doesn't notice, runs with one bare foot.

Races past dead and bleeding along the way, soldiers, villagers and horses alike. Bullets ricochet all around him.

He dives for cover at the edge of camp. Takes a few seconds to get his bearings, catch his breath.

Seemingly safe, he peeks from cover. Stares at the carnage still going on with terror filled eyes.

MATCH DISSOLVE TO:

INT. AIRPLANE - DAY (2016)

DENG ATEM, late 30s, stares at the Phoenix tarmac from his window seat.

He leans back, settles in with a grin.

Turns to the man who slipped into the middle seat with a gregarious, thousand watt, gap toothed smile.

DENG

Looks like we're neighbors.

It's a welcoming smile, one that has drawn people to him his whole life, and what a life it's been.

MIDDLE SEAT, 50s, nods back a quick hello with a heavy sigh.

MIDDLE SEAT

I hate these long flights.

DENG

Six hours? If only.

MIDDLE SEAT

Yeah, where you off to?

DENG

Africa.

The woman in the AISLE SEAT, 30s, glances at a magazine but actively listens in.

DENG (CONT'D)
South Sudan, in particular. For the first time since I left my family. Thirty-one years ago.

She leans across Middle Seat.

AISLE SEAT
You haven't seen your family in thirty years? I couldn't do that.

DENG
We've talked, sure. And Facebook, but this is my first time back.

MIDDLE SEAT
And you came here because...?

DENG
You've heard of the Lost Boys of Sudan?

Middle Seat nods, just goes along. Aisle Seat lights up.

AISLE SEAT
You were a child soldier?

MIDDLE SEAT
Okay, now you have my attention.

Deng pauses for effect. It's story time.

DENG
Yes. I was among the first to come to this country. Only I never considered myself lost.

EXT. SUDAN - DAY

Traditional drums and whistles fill the air. People sing as green countryside comes into view. Rivers. Mountains. Tall trees. Long grass sways in the breeze.

DENG (V.O.)
I knew exactly where I was from.

Deng, 8, in a blue and white striped soccer shirt with Maradona on the back, and his best friend ALEU, 8, in only worn khaki shorts, race through the tall grass.

They stop, face off against each other with spears. Battle with smiles on their faces. Laughter in their hearts.

Deng knocks the spear from Aleu's hands.

Aleu attacks, they wrestle. Hand to hand combat but neither gains the upper hand. They collapse, exhausted.

Deng and Aleu lie on their backs. Look at the sky, point out cloud formations. Until Deng jumps up.

He sheds his clothes as he races to the river. Jumps in. Aleu follows, does the same.

They swim, splash around, wrestle in the water. Until Aleu points to the shore. Two MONKEYS fight over their clothes.

Deng and Aleu hurry to the shore, chase after the monkeys. Throw rocks and sticks at them until the monkeys drop the clothes and disappear into the trees.

They laugh as they dress. Gather their spears, follow a small path back home, arms around each other's shoulders. It's been a full day.

EXT. DENG'S VILLAGE - DAY

Grass covered huts form a compound. Two act as living spaces, one for food storage. The family cow and goat have their own, Mom cooks in another one.

Drums and whistles grow louder, as does the singing. People dance with joy.

Men with scarred foreheads and missing bottom teeth. Women in colorful dresses, most with head coverings. Children who wear next to nothing but a smile.

DENG (V.O.)
I knew what tribe I was from. Who
my parents were, my extended
family.

Except for Deng and his siblings. They wear European clothes and shoes.

MAYIK ATEM, 30s, Deng's father known as Wa, steps into view with a RAM GOAT on a rope.

Not tall by Dinka standards, he carries himself bigger than he is because appearances are everything to him.

DENG (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Being a Big Man was important to
Wa.

WA
You honor me by being here today.
At our new home. With my mother. My
new wife. My new son, Juma.

MUDIT, 60s, smiles softly. ABUK, 20s, cradles baby JUMA, 1,
in her arms.

WA (CONT'D)
And, of course, my other children.
Nyariak, Awak and Malek.

NYARIAK, 9, AWAK, 5, and MALEK, 3, smile on command as Wa
says their name.

WA (CONT'D)
Do you not love their nice clothes?

DENG (V.O.)
The clothes and shoes were one way
for him to show he was a big man.

Aleu, off to the side with Deng, elbows him as if to say -
what the heck? He forgot you.

NYARIAK
Did you forget someone, Wa?

Wa follows Nyariak's gaze as she nods towards Deng. Wa looks
to Deng, dismissive.

WA
I have decided Mam is going to live
with my brother in Khartoum. He is
smart and will go to school.

Everyone looks to Deng in amazement. Deng himself looks
surprised, it's news to him.

WA (CONT'D)
That way, we will not have to feed
him. The boy eats too much.

An uncomfortable quiet fills the air, until Deng laughs. Then
everyone else laughs.

DENG (V.O.)
It turns out he wasn't kidding. He
took me on his next "business trip"
of which I was never to speak of.

INT. UNCLE MALAL'S HOME - DAY

Two room home, sparsely decorated.

UNCLE MALAL, 30s, skinny with a long beard, in civilian clothes even though he was a criminal investigator.

UNCLE MALAL

I am sorry, I cannot do what you ask.

Wa nods, disappointed.

UNCLE MALAL (CONT'D)

Because of the coup in our country, I will most likely lose my job.

Deng nods, secretly happy.

UNCLE MALAL (CONT'D)

And probably be thrown in jail. Makoldit would have nowhere to live nor a place in school.

EXT. DENG'S VILLAGE - DAY

Wa holds the goat rope up for everyone to see.

WA

I offer this ram to Nhialic Wa to keep us safe.

A BENY-BITH, 60s, in RED with several dirty spears, steps next to Wa. Well respected because they speak to the gods, he mumbles to himself, chants, shakes his spears.

BENY-BITH

You will be safe. The Murahaleen will not return.

While the rest of the crowd cheers, Deng leans close to Aleu.

DENG

If his words can stop them, how can the Murahaleen come at all?

Aleu shushes Deng.

ALEU

Beny-Bith always tell the truth.